Begum, having been married under duress to his great enemy, Shaibani Khan, returned to her brother when the khan was killed, and was welcomed with joy. She married again and became an honoured matriarch, the Padishah Begum of the family – certainly no harbinger of shame upon it.[51]

'It is in Akbar's time,' Ruby Lal argues, 'that a clearly demarcated "sacred incarcerated" sphere emerges as the space of the Mughal domestic.' Quite literally so. Earlier, 'harem' was only a collective noun to describe the women – wives, relatives and attendants – in a household; now it was a place, a 'fixed realm',[52] as Lal writes, '"sacred and hidden" – a sanctum sanctorum'.[53]

Abul Fazl describes how Akbar 'made a large enclosure with fine buildings inside, where he reposes'. Five thousand women – queens, princesses, attendants – lived in these palaces and apartments, guarded by layer upon layer of security: female soldiers, then a guard of *kwajasara*s, eunuchs; separate troops of Rajputs, amirs and *ahadi*s – not to mention the porters at the gates.[54]

It was, as Mukhia describes it, 'a fortress-like institution', unprecedented in the dynasty. Such, in fact, was Akbar's growing 'obsession with female chastity' that even the names of the royal women 'begin to get omitted' from official chronicles. Hamida herself is only ever 'named' by her title, Maryam Makani, in the *Akbarnama*; many others must make do with 'cupola of chastity', Abul Fazl's favourite shorthand for noblewoman.

Akbar's relationship with his harem – like Akbar's relationship with his nobility, his friends and his God – was complicated; his 'attitudes towards sexuality . . . an ensemble of paradoxes'.[55]

For all that he felt compelled to lock them up in luxury, Akbar was deeply attached to, even dependent on, many of the women in his harem, particularly his mother. Once, impatient for Hamida to join him in enjoying the delights of Kashmir, Akbar wrote her a lovely couplet: 'The pilgrim may go to the K'aaba to perform the haj / O God! May the K'aaba come towards us!'[56] Years later, Akbar borrowed a painting of the Madonna from visiting Jesuits because he wanted to show it to his wives and daughters.[57] The Fathers were worried they might never see their painting again, but Akbar returned it, only to ask for it one more time. Hamida wanted to see it, the emperor explained, and 'although his mother was a very old lady, she